ReFind

Intelligent Lost & Found, in Your Pocket

From lost to found — automatically.

App Business Plan

Mobile Intelligent Application — Course Project

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1. Executive Summary

Every year, a huge number of personal belongings — phones, keys, ID cards, laptops, water bottles, earbuds — go missing on university campuses, in shopping centres, on public transport, and at large events. Existing lost-and-found services are almost entirely **passive**: the loser must search through piles of unclaimed items or scroll through dozens of unrelated social-media posts, while the finder often has no practical way to reach the owner. The result is a low return rate, frustrated users, and heavy manual workload for campus security offices and service desks.

ReFind is a mobile application that turns lost-and-found from a searching problem into a **matching problem**. A user who loses or finds an item simply uploads a photo with the time and location. ReFind applies **image recognition and contextual matching** (category, colour, location, time) to identify likely pairs automatically. When a strong match is found, **both users are notified instantly**. To prevent false claims, the claimed owner must pass a **private verification question** before any return is arranged.

ReFind starts where the pain is most concentrated: **university campuses**, where users are digitally native, density is high, and one institution can onboard thousands of users at once. After proving the model on campuses, the same platform extends naturally to shopping centres, public transport systems and large events — any environment where items are lost in high volume within a bounded area.

The business model is simple: the service is **free for individual users**, while **organisations pay a subscription** for management dashboards, staff workflows and data-analytics tools. Because matching is automated by machine learning, the marginal cost of serving an additional campus is close to zero, and the social mission — returning people their belongings — is also the product's growth engine: every successful return is a word-of-mouth story.

Key facts.

- **Product:** ReFind, an AI-powered lost-and-found app (Android first).
- **Users:** free for students and the general public.
- **Revenue:** B2B subscription from campuses, venues and transport operators, plus a merchant-sponsored reward pool.
- **Beachhead:** our own university campus, then city-wide institutions.
- **Core AI:** image-embedding matching + contextual filtering + LLM-generated verification questions.
- **Incentives:** owner-set rewards in escrow and merchant-sponsored points — escrow and verification close the fraud and extortion levers. The platform never funds a reward itself.

2. The Problem

2.1 Lost items rarely find their way home

Losing a phone, wallet or student ID is not a trivial inconvenience: it interrupts study, work and daily life, and replacement carries real cost. Yet the overwhelming majority of lost items that *are* found by someone never return to their owners, because the two parties have no efficient way to meet.

2.2 Current solutions are passive and fragmented

- **Lost-property offices and service desks** store found items, but they are passive warehouses: owners must actively call or visit, describe the item, and hope someone checks. There is no proactive notification, and coverage ends at the desk's opening hours.
- **Social media and group chats** (campus WeChat/QQ groups, WhatsApp groups, Facebook groups) carry lost-and-found posts, but they are unstructured: photos are buried in unrelated chatter, posts expire, and there is no matching at all — a finder and a loser of the same umbrella can post in two different groups and never see each other.
- **Physical noticeboards** are even slower, with no photos, no search and no reach beyond one corridor.

2.3 Three structural gaps

1. **No automatic matching.** Nobody connects "lost" and "found" reports of the same item; the burden of searching falls entirely on the person who already had the bad luck of losing something.
2. **No trust layer.** Even when a channel works, anyone can claim anything: "yes, that's my phone" is unverifiable, so finders are rightly reluctant to hand items over.
3. **No tools for organisations.** Campuses, malls and transport operators manage hundreds of items per month with spreadsheets and paper; they have no dashboard, no analytics and no API — an unserved B2B need sitting right next to the consumer pain.

3. App Overview: ReFind

ReFind is a mobile app (Android first, iOS later) with two simple flows: **report** and **claim**. Everything else — matching, notification, verification — is handled by the platform. The complete loop has six steps (Figure 1).

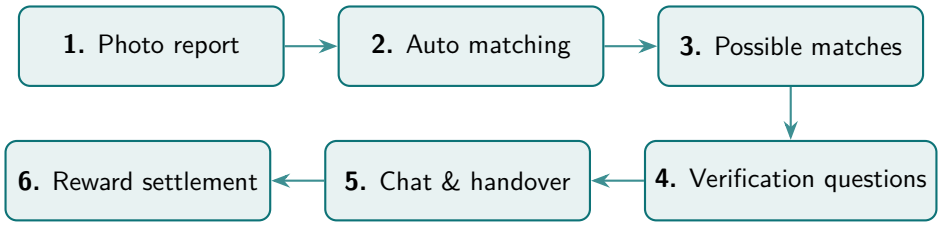


Figure 1: The ReFind loop: from photo report to reward settlement. Every step is guarded — matching by confidence thresholds, claims by verification, rewards by escrow.

3.1 Core user flows

Report.
The user uploads one or more photos, selects a category, and adds the time and location (autofilled from GPS and the report timestamp, both editable). A short free-text description and optional private details (stickers, scratches, contents) complete the report in under a minute.

Automatic matching.
ReFind compares every new report against existing reports using image similarity and contextual signals. High-confidence pairs trigger **instant push notifications to both parties**; borderline pairs appear in a "possible matches" list for the user to review.

Verified claim.
When an owner contacts a finder, ReFind asks the owner item-specific verification questions generated from the *private* details. Only after passing verification is the in-app chat opened, so the finder never hands a phone to a stranger who simply saw the post.

Optional reward.
When reporting, the owner may attach a reward — set by the owner, **held in escrow by the platform**, and released to the finder only when both sides confirm the handover. Rewards settle as ReFind points redeemable for campus-merchant perks by default, with cash escrow for high-value items as a later phase (Section 8).

Return & feedback.
Both sides confirm the handover and rate the interaction. Confirmed returns feed the matching system as positive training signal, build the finder's public "good samaritan" reputation, and release the escrowed reward; the organisation's dashboard records the item as resolved.

3.2 Feature set at a glance

- **Photo-first reporting** with guided capture tips (sharp, well-lit, distinctive angle) to maximise match quality.
- **AI matching engine** combining image embeddings with category, colour, time and location filters (Section 4).
- **Proactive notifications** — the loser does not search; the system tells both sides when the same item appears.
- **Private verification questions** as an anti-fraud gate (Section 4).
- **Incentive layer** — optional owner-set rewards in escrow plus merchant-sponsored ReFind points, so returning an item is recognised concretely instead of relying on goodwill alone; every reward path is guarded by the anti-abuse controls in Section 10.3.
- **In-app chat and handover confirmation** with safety guidance (meet at campus security points).
- **Organisation console (B2B):** item intake, storage location tracking, status workflow, expiry and disposal reminders, and return-rate analytics.

4. How the Intelligence Works

ReFind is, at its core, a *mobile intelligent application*: the defensible part of the product is the matching and verification pipeline, not the forms and feeds.

4.1 Matching pipeline

1. **On-device image embedding.** Each uploaded photo is passed through a pre-trained vision model (CLIP-style image encoder, deployable on-device via TensorFlow Lite with a server-side fallback). The output is a normalised feature vector that captures the visual "essence" of the item — shape, colour, texture — independent of background and lighting.
2. **Contextual filtering.** Candidate pairs are filtered by the structured signals users already provide: category, colour, a bounded time window, and a geographic radius around the reported location.

3. **Composite score.** Final score = cosine similarity of image embeddings combined with a weighted context score. Pairs above the auto-match threshold notify both users; pairs in a grey zone are surfaced as "possible matches"; the rest are silently indexed.
4. **Feedback loop.** Confirmed matches and confirmed non-matches tune the thresholds and weights per category (a laptop and a water bottle need different sensitivities).

4.2 LLM-generated verification questions

When a claim is made, the system generates item-specific questions from the owner's *private* detail field (never shown publicly), e.g.

- "What sticker is on the back of the laptop?"
- "What is currently in the bottle's side pocket?"
- "Is there any damage on the left corner? Describe it."

The claimant must answer correctly before contact is unlocked. This single feature converts ReFind from "another noticeboard" into a *trusted* channel, and it is generated by an LLM from the owner's own description — zero manual configuration by staff.

4.3 Privacy by design

Photos and locations are personal data. ReFind minimises by default: photos are visible only to matched counterparties and (for organisations) staff; precise locations are blurred to a zone-level for public display; reports auto-expire; and users can delete a report and all associated data at any time, in line with GDPR and comparable personal-information regulations.

5. Market Analysis

5.1 Who feels the pain

- **Individuals:** every student and commuter is a potential user; losing an ID card, laptop or headphones is a near-universal experience.
- **Universities:** campus security and student-services desks accumulate hundreds of unclaimed items per term with manual, low-tech processes.
- **Venues and transport:** malls, stadiums, metro and bus operators publicly report tens to hundreds of thousands of lost items per year per network, and run dedicated departments to handle them.

5.2 Beachhead: universities

We deliberately start with universities because they combine all the conditions a two-sided, local-network product needs:

- **Density:** 10,000–30,000 users on one campus, losing items in the same buildings daily.
- **Homogeneity:** shared locations, shared terminology, one security office to partner with.
- **Digital-native users:** near-zero onboarding friction; students already live in campus-specific apps and group chats.
- **A natural champion:** the student union or campus security office can endorse the app and feed their existing stock of unclaimed items into it, instantly solving the two-sided cold-start problem from the supply side.

5.3 Market sizing (estimates)

Layer	Definition and rough size
TAM	Digital lost-and-found for bounded venues (universities, malls, transit, events). There are more than 160 higher-education institutions in the UK and over 3,000 in China alone, plus thousands of large venues — a global opportunity in the thousands of potential B2B accounts.
SAM	Institutions in our launch regions that currently run a physical lost-property operation and could adopt a managed digital platform within 3 years: estimated in the hundreds of accounts.
SOM	Our 3-year target: 1 flagship campus pilot (year 1), 10 paying organisations (year 2), 40 paying organisations (year 3).

Table 1: Top-down market framing. All figures are planning estimates, to be refined with pilot data.

5.4 Competition and positioning

The market already has two clusters of incumbents, and naming them sharpens our position. **B2B back-office software** — Crowdfind and Chargerback (US venues and stadiums), iLost (Europe) and Lost and Found Software (aviation and transit) — digitises the *staff side*: intake, storage, claim web-forms and reporting for the counter that holds the item. **AI matching platforms** are newer: Boomerang (US, venture-backed) uses machine learning to match photos and descriptions of lost items for hotels, airports and stadiums — validating both the technology and institutional willingness to pay for recovery. Both clusters, however, assume the item sits at an organisation's counter. None of them operates a peer-to-peer network in which *other students* are the finders — which is where most campus items actually are — and none combines automatic matching with a verification gate and an incentive layer in one consumer product.

	Auto-matching	Proactive notification	Anti-fraud verification	Org. tooling
Lost-property desks	–	–	partial	–
Social media groups	–	–	–	–
Noticeboards	–	–	–	–
General marketplaces	–	–	–	partial
B2B lost-property software (Crowdfind, Chargerback, iLost)	partial	partial	–	✓
AI matching apps (Boomerang)	✓	partial	partial	✓
ReFind	✓	✓	✓	✓

Table 2: Competitive comparison. ✓ = full support; *partial* = manual review only, single scenario only, or no automatic notification; – = not available. Existing software digitises the back office or matches claims at a single venue's counter; none combines a peer-to-peer consumer network with verification and incentives.

Strategic reading. Boomerang's venture backing and growth validate that AI matching works and that institutions pay for recovery. ReFind attacks the gap this wave leaves open: the peer-to-peer campus network, where finders are students rather than staff, gated by verification and motivated by escrowed rewards. Our moat is narrow but real: the matching pipeline improves

with local data (each campus's photos make its matches better), network effects are local and fast to establish — the first credible app at one campus is hard to displace — and the B2B console creates switching costs on the institutional side.

6. Unique Selling Proposition

USP. ReFind is the only lost-and-found product built as a *peer-to-peer campus network*: it matches the photos of losers and finders automatically, verifies every claim with questions only the true owner can answer, and rewards the return through platform-escrowed incentives — free for students, funded by institutions.

Three pillars back the statement:

1. **Matching, not searching.** Every incumbent channel makes the unlucky person do the work. ReFind inverts this: the system watches all reports and tells both sides when the same item appears. B2B software (Section 5.4) digitises a counter; ReFind connects the campus population itself.
2. **Trust engineered in, not bolted on.** LLM-generated verification questions and escrowed rewards are structural, not policies: a false claimant cannot pass the gate, and a hostage-taking finder has no lever. No competitor combines the two.
3. **Aligned economics.** Students pay nothing, ever. Institutions pay because the platform measurably raises return rates and cuts desk workload. Merchants pay to appear at the moment of a happy return. Every side's incentive points the same way — more verified returns.

In one line for users: *"Lose less. One photo, and the campus finds it back for you."* In one line for institutions: *"Double your return rate without adding a single desk hour."* Both claims are falsifiable by the pilot (Section 13), which is the point.

7. Target User Personas

ReFind serves two consumer roles and one institutional role. All three must be satisfied for a single return to happen, so the product is designed against all three at once.

	Maya, 20 undergraduate	**Daniel, 23** postgrad teaching assistant	**Officer Chen, 45** campus security supervisor
Situation	Loses earbuds, student card or laptop at the library, gym or canteen; busy, mobile-first, has posted to campus group chats before and got nothing back.	Often the first to notice forgotten laptops and phones in teaching rooms; willing to help but has no time to trek to the security desk and no safe way to hand items over.	Manages 300+ unclaimed items per term in spreadsheets; answers calls from anxious students and parents; under pressure to raise the return rate with a fixed headcount.
Goals	Get the item back tonight, without begging in ten group chats.	Do the right thing with one minute of effort — and maybe a coffee for the trouble.	Higher return rate, auditable records, less repetitive intake work.
Frustrations	Passive desks and unstructured group chats; no way to prove an item is hers once someone answers.	Fear of scams or awkward negotiations with strangers; uncertainty about liability.	Manual matching of claims to shelves; no data to justify budget.
ReFind	40-second report, automatic match notification, verified claim, handover at a campus point she already passes.	One photo upload, auto-match does the finding, escrowed reward settles instantly, handover witnessed at a staffed point.	Organisation console: intake, storage tracking, claim moderation, return-rate analytics he can show the administration.

Table 3: Primary personas. Maya drives demand, Daniel drives supply, Officer Chen drives adoption and pays.

The campus context is what makes the triangle work: Maya and Daniel overlap physically daily, and Officer Chen's endorsement removes the trust deficit a stranger-to-stranger app would face.

8. Business Model

8.1 Revenue streams

Free for individuals (forever).
Reporting, matching, notifications, verification and chat are free. This maximises adoption, which is the asset institutions pay for.

Organisation subscription (B2B SaaS).
Campuses, malls, transport operators and event organisers pay per site per year for the organisation console: staff workflows, storage tracking, moderated claims, branded app page, and analytics (return rate, hot-spot map, item-category trends, seasonal staffing hints).

Event packages (optional add-on).
Short-term deployments for conferences, festivals and stadiums: a branded instance live for the event duration.

Merchant-sponsored reward pool.
Campus cafés, bookstores and gyms sponsor ReFind points that finders redeem for real perks; sponsors get branded exposure inside the app and at the moment of a successful return — the happiest moment a campus marketer can buy. This stream strengthens the incentive layer without touching consumer pricing: the platform never funds rewards, it only escrows and settles them.

8.2 Indicative pricing

Plan	What is included	Price (indicative)
Student / public	Full consumer app	Free
Campus	Console + analytics + moderation + support	$2,500 / site / year
Large venue / transit	Multi-site, SSO, API, SLA	$4,000–8,000 / year
Event	Branded temporary instance	$300 / event

Table 4: Pricing sketch for planning; to be validated in pilot negotiations.

8.3 Unit economics logic

Serving one additional institution is almost pure margin: infrastructure cost is dominated by photo storage and embedding inference, both of which cost fractions of a cent per report. An LLM-generated verification question costs on the order of $0.002 per claim. At pilot scale (a few thousand reports per term per campus), the entire AI cost is negligible next to one subscription cheque — the constraint on growth is sales and onboarding, not compute.

9. Marketing Channels and Go-to-Market

9.1 Marketing channels

Channels are chosen against the personas (Section 7): each channel must reach either the loser at the moment of loss, the finder at the moment of finding, or the institution that controls adoption.

Channel	Persona	Cost	Role in the funnel
Security-office partnership	Chen	Free	Endorsement, seed inventory of unclaimed items, staffed handover points — the trust foundation.
Student ambassador program	Maya, Daniel	$500 / term	Peer credibility in faculties and dorms; ambassadors seed the supply side among finders.
Loss-hotspot posters + QR	Maya	$300 / term	Captured intent exactly where loss happens (library, gym, canteen), at exam-season spikes.
Campus social media & group chats	Maya, Daniel	Free	Awareness and launch bursts; also our acquisition surface for the concierge validation (Section 13).
Return stories (earned)	All	Free	Every verified return is shareable proof; with consent, “reunion” posts become the growth loop.

Table 5: Channel–persona–cost mapping for the campus phase.

9.2 Phase 1 — Flagship campus pilot

1. **Partner first, launch second.** Sign the student union / campus security office as design partner. Their back catalogue of unclaimed items seeds the supply side on day one.
2. **Campus ambassador program.** Recruit 10–20 student ambassadors across faculties and dorms; ambassadors get early access and swag, and run dorm-level demos.

3. **Moment marketing.** Losses spike at exam season, orientation week and library closing time — run "Found something? One photo returns it." campaigns at those exact moments and locations (library, gym, canteen).
4. **Let returns market the product.** Every successful return is a story: with user consent, share "reunion" posts on campus social channels. Return rate is our north-star metric and our best advertisement.

9.3 Phase 2 — Replicate and convert

Once one campus shows a measured return-rate uplift, the playbook repeats at 3–5 nearby campuses. Institutions that actively use the console during the free pilot are converted to paid subscriptions; the pilot contract includes a defined conversion point so the free period is a sales process, not an open tab.

9.4 Phase 3 — Adjacent venues

The same stack serves shopping centres, transit operators and events. We only enter these after the campus playbook is documented, because each new vertical needs one dedicated integration effort (e.g. transport operators need cross-city item routing).

10. Technical Feasibility

10.1 Architecture overview

- **Mobile client:** Android (Kotlin, Jetpack Compose) first; iOS later. Image embedding runs on-device via TensorFlow Lite where possible, with a server fallback — good for latency, offline tolerance and privacy.
- **Backend:** REST API; PostgreSQL with the `pgvector` extension for similarity search; object storage for photos; push notifications via FCM.
- **AI services:** pre-trained CLIP-style encoder for embeddings (no model training required for MVP); perceptual hashing to suppress duplicate/re-uploaded photos; LLM API for verification-question generation and abuse filtering of report text.

10.2 Why this is achievable

Every AI component uses a *pre-trained* model behind a stable API — we are solving an integration and product problem, not a research problem. The hardest engineering risks (threshold calibration, false-positive fatigue) are addressed by the human-in-the-loop "possible matches" design: the system assists, the user decides, and every decision improves the thresholds.

10.3 Trust and safety engineering

An incentive layer has two failure modes, and both are handled by design: with *no* incentive, the supply of returns dies because goodwill alone does not move people to run errands for strangers; with an *unguarded* incentive, bad actors arrive — false claimants, and finders who hold items hostage for more money. ReFind's controls:

- **Escrow closes the extortion lever.** The reward is fixed by the owner and held by the platform before the handover is even arranged. A finder who demands "extra cash or no phone" gains nothing: the negotiated amount already exists, and off-platform demands are a reportable, bannable offence.

- **Verification closes the claim lever.** LLM-generated questions from private details (Section 4.2) gate every claim, and high-value categories (electronics, IDs) settle at staffed campus security points with an ID check.
- **Anomaly detection closes the farming lever.** Signals such as one account repeatedly "finding" high-value items, failed verification attempts, and report-rate spikes feed a moderation queue in the organisation console; confirmed fraud means suspension and, for theft, referral to campus security.

Report/claim abuse is additionally rate-limited and text-filtered. All personal data handling follows data-minimisation and user-deletion rights (Section 4.3).

11. Roadmap and Milestones

Phase	Timing	Goals and exit criteria
M1 — Design	Months 1–2	Requirements, UI prototypes, matching-pipeline spike on sample photos. Exit: clickable prototype + offline matching demo.
M2 — MVP	Months 3–5	Android app: report, browse, image + context matching, notifications. Exit: end-to-end match found in test set.
M3 — Trust layer	Months 6–7	Verification questions, escrowed rewards, in-app chat, organisation console v1. Exit: full return flow completed in beta.
M4 — Campus pilot	Month 8+	Flagship campus live with security office; measure return rate vs. baseline. Exit: agreed pilot KPI met.
M5 — Commercialise	Year 2	Convert pilot to paid; onboard 10 organisations; begin iOS client. Exit: first recurring revenue.

Table 6: Product and commercial roadmap.

12. Financial Overview and Key Metrics

12.1 Cost structure

Item	Notes	Year-1 estimate
Cloud & storage	App server, PostgreSQL, photo storage	$1,200
AI inference	Embeddings + LLM verification at pilot scale	$500
App distribution	Developer program fees	$125
Pilot marketing	Ambassadors, print, launch events	$1,000
Contingency	—	$500
Total		**$~4,000**

Table 7: Year-1 operating cost at pilot scale. Development labour is excluded (student project; for a funded venture this becomes the dominant line).

12.2 Revenue projection

	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3
Paying organisations	0 (free pilots)	10	40
Avg. subscription	—	$2,500	$3,200
Revenue	**$0**	**$25,000**	**$~130,000**
Operating cost	$4,000	$12,000	$45,000
Net	**–$4,000**	**+$13,000**	**+$~85,000**

Table 8: Three-year planning projection. Break-even occurs during Year 2 with the first subscription cohort.

The projection is intentionally conservative: it assumes revenue comes only from B2B subscriptions and ignores event packages and any consumer monetisation. The strategic point is that the model reaches break-even at a scale (10 organisations) that is reachable by direct campus-to-campus sales, without requiring mass consumer monetisation.

12.3 Key metrics

The plan is managed by a small set of metrics with explicit targets; each one can kill or confirm an assumption in this document.

Metric	Pilot target	Why it matters
Verified returns / month (north star)	150 by end of campus pilot	Returns are the product; every other metric is a proxy for this one.
Auto-match precision	≥80% of notifications are true pairs	False-match notifications destroy trust faster than missed matches lose returns.
D7 retention (closed beta)	≥25%	Losing things is episodic; retention must come from the network's ongoing value, not one user's bad luck.
Median time-to-return	<48 hours	The headline number for all marketing claims and the institutional sales pitch.
Pilot → paid conversion	≥40% of active pilots	Validates that free pilots are a sales pipeline, not charity.
Gross margin	>85%	Confirms the near-zero-marginal-cost SaaS assumption behind Section 8.

Table 9: Key metrics with pilot-phase targets.

13. Channels to Validate the App

Before and alongside the MVP build, four validation channels are used, ordered from cheapest to most expensive, each with a falsifiable success criterion:

1. **Landing page + waitlist.** A one-page pitch with campus social posts driving traffic,

sign-up open before the app exists. *Criterion:* at least 8% of visitors join the waitlist.

2. **Concierge MVP in campus groups.** For two weeks the team manually matches lost and found posts in existing group chats with a shared spreadsheet and the matching heuristics. *Criterion:* at least 5 verified returns complete end-to-end, and participants agree to move to the app when it ships.
3. **Instrumented closed beta.** Fifty students on the full MVP. *Criteria:* D7 retention $\geq$25%, at least 60% of reports receive a candidate match within 24 hours, auto-match precision stays $\geq$80%.
4. **Pilot KPI review with the security office.** Measured return-rate uplift against the pre-app baseline plus staff hours saved per week. *Criterion:* the uplift converts the office into the first paying organisation (Section 9, Phase 2).

Each channel de-risks a different layer — demand, matching quality, retention, and willingness to pay — so a failure pinpoints the broken assumption instead of sinking the project.

14. Risk Analysis

Risk	Level	Mitigation
Two-sided cold start	High	Seed supply side via campus security office's existing item stock; launch in one dense campus, not city-wide.
False claims / fraud	Medium	LLM verification questions, claim audit log, escalation to staff for high-value items.
Reward abuse (hostage pricing, theft-for-reward)	Medium	Fixed escrowed rewards remove the negotiation lever; security-point settlement with ID checks; anomaly detection on repeat high-value finds; suspension and referral.
Privacy / data protection	Medium	Data minimisation, zone-level locations, auto-expiry, one-tap deletion; GDPR-aligned design.
Matching quality below expectation	Medium	Human-in-the-loop "possible matches", per-category thresholds, feedback loop; on-device embedding with server fallback.
Low institutional willingness to pay	Medium	Free pilot with defined conversion point; lead with measured return-rate uplift and staff-time savings.
Incumbent copying	Low	Local data moat, institution lock-in via console and analytics.

Table 10: Key risks and mitigations.

15. Team

Member	Role and responsibility
Heng Liu	Product & growth — requirements, business model, pilot partnerships; also design system, campus ambassador program and pilot metrics.
Honghui Zhang	Android engineer — app architecture and on-device ML integration; TensorFlow Lite embeddings and client-side performance.
Yuchen Huang	Backend & AI engineer — matching service, verification pipeline and data layer; pgvector similarity search and LLM integration.

Table 11: Team roles and responsibilities.

Concluding note. ReFind takes a problem everyone has personally experienced, replaces passive searching with proactive AI matching, and attaches a clean B2B revenue model to a free consumer service. The beachhead is one campus we can walk to, the technology is pre-trained and proven, and every successful return makes both the network and the model stronger.